NAMAMI GANGE AND INDIA'S GLOBAL SUCCESS



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May be, even five years back, the task of cleaning River Ganga looked a mission impossible, given its complexity, spread and diversity and its history and geography. It definitely was, when Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi embarked on the cleansing of the River Ganga and its tributaries, launching Namami Gange as one of the flagship programs of his Government in 2014-15, with a committed budget of Rs 20,000 Crores. His determination and commitment to the project was beyond doubt, with him famously saying, *"Ma Ganga ne mujhe bulaya hai"*.



Historically, many attempts, starting with Ganga Action Plan in 1985 were done to clean river Ganga, but failed to achieve the results contemplated, mainly due to their piecemeal approaches and lack of long term financial support. Identifying and correcting the reasons for the earlier failures, when the Namami Gange was launched, it had its task cut out clearly- follow an integrated river basin approach, based on scientific principles and data based interventions, with people's participation. The implementing agency, the National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG), which existed since 2011, was empowered in 2016 with an Authority order to take decisions under the overall guidance of the National Ganga Council, headed by Prime Minister himself, expanding its financial powers to sanction projects estimated upto Rs 1000 crores and giving it more administrative flexibility to implement projects, efficiently. NMCG was also given regulatory powers under the Environmental Protection Act, 1986.

Though it had a slow start, the outcome of the Namami Gange program, particularly in the last 3



years has been phenomenal. With the creation of about 3000 MLD sewage treatment capacity- almost 2000 MLD in the last 2 years,- the ingress of untreated sewage into the rivers has been significantly reduced. Main stem of River Ganga has almost been cleaned up, with no polluted stretches in priority categories 1 to 4, as per the CPCB report of 2023. The focus is now shifted to clean Ganga's tributaries like Yamuna, Hindon Kali etc. This success is corroborated by the reports of Wildlife Institute of India, which has reported increased biodiversity in these improved stretches- increased population (from 2500 to 4500-5000) and increased river stretches for sightings of Gangetic Dolphins; and increased numbers of Otters, Gharials, Turtles, fishes etc. On 13 December, 2022, at the Biodiversity COP15, Namami-Gange was recognized as one of the top ten "World Restoration Flagships" by a consortium led by UNEP & FAO after examiing 160 similar projects across the globe "for halting, reversing Environmental degradation, with people's participation."

With the primary objective of restoring the ecological balance of the Ganga basin, Namami Gange's multifaceted approach involves biodiversity conservation, waste management, public awareness initiatives and riverfront development. Namami Gange rests upon five main pillars: Nirmal-Ganga (unpolluted river), Aviral-Ganga (unrestricted flow), Jan-Ganga (people's participation), Gyan-Ganga (knowledge and research-based interventions) and Arth-Ganga, (making river-people connect through an economic-bridge). Arth Ganga epitomizes a fundamental shift towards a holistic approach to river conservation. Robust data-driven insights highlight Namami Gange's impact, with 457 projects sanctioned totaling approximately Rs 38,438 crores, of which 197 are related to wastewater treatment. These projects are monitored 24X7 with the newly launched portal "PRAYAG"-Platform for Real time monitoring of Yamuna and Ganga and its tributaries. Nearly 2500 District Ganga Committee (4M -Monthly Mandated Minuted Monitored) meetings held since its launch in April 2022 have helped to de-centralise and involve local stakeholders in planning & monitoring of NMCG actvities.

A crucial part of Arth Ganga, is promotion of livelihoods and cultural enrichment along the Ganga River, under the JALAJ initiative. JALAJ Awareness and Marketing Center (JAMC) at Dilli Haat, New Delhi, showcases chemical fertilizer-free natural farming products from the Ganga Basin, natural food items, handicrafts, agarbattis made by women's self-help groups and Ganga Praharis and bottled Ganga-jal. JALAJ is a perfect example of NMCG's efforts in fostering economic empowerment and skill development in local communities.

Global River Cities Alliance (GRCA) led by NMCG was launched during COP28 in Dubai on 10 December, 2023, in the presence of Ministers and senior officials from 9 countries, international funding agencies and knowledge management institutions. Sri Sadhguru, the founder of ISHA foundation, also graced the occasion. GRCA was formed expanding the existing River Cities Alliance (RCA) formed by NMCG and NIUA with 142 Indian river cities as members. GRCA is envisaged as a knowledge exchange platform, enabling knowledge exchange and technology transfers among cities. Advancing with the Urban Management Plan (URMP) aligned with Sustainable Development Goals, NMCG demonstrates a commitment to play a lead role in addressing environmental, social, and economic challenges of member cities.

Amidst the pressing threats of global warming and environmental decline, Namami Gange ushers an era of revitalized river ecosystems. It promises ecological sustainability and economic growth for communities along the banks of the Ganga and its tributaries.